

Manu Bhaker leading the charge in Indian shooting's revival

The 22-year-old's [twin Olympic medals](#), Paralympic successes, the emergence of 16-year-old Parth Mane and the upcoming Shooting League of India highlight a transformative year for the sport.

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In 2024, the Year of the Dragon, Manu Bhaker almost slew one.

A mere 0.1 separated internet sensation Yeji Kim and the Indian shooting star on the tally when the latter was forced to settle for a bronze medal during the 10m air pistol final of the Paris Olympics. The point difference, when scaled on the scoring ring, is about 1 mm. To put matters into perspective, that's approximately the diameter of the tip of the graphite lead of a sharp pencil!

If Yeji were to get the raw deal, maybe Manu, in imperious form on the said day, would have gone on to put the other Korean and eventual winner Oh Ye Jin to the sword as well. Indeed, she would have had her work cut out should the events have unfolded in the said manner, given Oh ended up registering an Olympic record score of 243.2. But a little wishful thinking never hurts.

Despite having pocketed India's first shooting medal in 12 years since Vijay Kumar's silver in the 25m rapid fire pistol in London, Manu, in all probability, would have thought about the same when she decided to retire for that night. The 22-year-old was yet to participate in two more events.

Only one more podium finish would have made her independent India's first athlete to win two medals in a

single edition of the Olympic Games. She would also become only the second Indian female athlete to bag multiple Olympic medals after badminton ace P. V. Sindhu.

Manu sped past these milestones when help arrived in the shape of another 22-year-old in Sarabjot Singh only a day later, on July 29.

In the bronze medal match of the 10m air pistol mixed team event, Manu went up against a very familiar face — that of Oh!

Accompanying the OR holder was Asian Games silver medallist Lee Wonho. Although Sarabjot dropped 11 points in his three series, a 291 from Manu, coupled with a slew of 9s from Lee and Oh, saw South Korea sink to a 16-10 defeat and take a bite of the humble pie. This victory saw Sarabjot heave a sigh of relief, with the shooter having missed out on a place in the 10m air pistol final three days earlier after he shot one 'x' (inner-10) less than the eighth-placed Robin Walter of Germany.